History tells us that the Greater Bharat always saw invasions predominantly through the Khyber Pass. A few prominent examples are Cyrus, Darius I, Genghis Khan, Duwa Khan, Qutlugh Khwaja and Kebek. Before Kushan led their feet through the pass, it wasn't widely used as a trade route.[*] The Khyber Pass had turned into an important part of the Silk Road (the major trade route that connected Eastern Asia with Europe).[†] One might be able to understand the giantess of this from the fact that once the Parthian Empire fought to control these passes to draw massive profits from the trade in jade, silk and other luxuries that moved to Western Asia and Europe. Once it was the phase when through the Khyber Pass, Gandhara had become a regional node of trade connecting Bagram in Afghanistan to Taxila (now in Pakistan). It catered to Indian luxury goods like pepper, ivory and textiles as a contribution to the Silk Road commerce.[‡]

Islamic invaders such as Mahmud Ghaznavi, Afghan Muhammad Ghori, and the Turkic-Mongols also entered through this pass. It was in AD 1834 that Maharaja Ranjit Singh took complete control of Khyber Pass, erasing the Islamic influence. The Khalsa general, Hari Singh Nalwa, who saw through the Khyber Pass for many years had become a household name in Afghanistan.[*]

It was the period when India was geographically best defined as being 'Khyber to Kanyakumari'.[†] In the north of Khyber Pass lay the country of Mullagori, which housed the Shalmani tribes. Down the south, lay Afridi Tirah and the pass was full of the people from the Afridi clan. Since the Islamic invasion, the centuries-old Pashtun clans, especially the Afghan Shinwaris and Afridis have regarded the Khyber as their own preserve and interestingly have levied heavy a toll on travellers in the name of safe conduct. They have thoroughly relied upon it as their main source of income, and hence there is resistance to the challenges to the Shinwari Authority.[‡] During the First World War, the British built a railway line through the pass for strategic reasons. The Khyber Pass railway from Jamrud, near Peshawar, to the Afghan border near Landi Kotal was opened in AD 1925. In the Second World War, dragon teeth made of concrete were built on the valley floor as the British feared the German (NSDAP) tank invasion.[§] The famous 'hippie trail' (1950s to 1970s) saw the Japanese and the Westerners travel across the pass on bus or car right from Kābul to the borders of Afghanistan. At the Pakistani frontier post, the advisory was given to the travellers to not adventure away from the road as the location was in control of the Federally Administered Tribal Area. Following the customs formalities, a brisk daytime drive in the pass was made. One could see